

APHA post-Brexit and the Animal Health Certificate: analysis of the new UK pet importation regime

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Abstract

Objective. To analyze the impact of Brexit on the UK pet importation regime and the Animal Health Certificate (AHC) requirements for dogs and cats from countries not listed in Part 1. **Method.** Review of the APHA/DEFRA regulatory framework in force since January 2021, AHC requirements, protocols applicable to dogs from high-risk countries such as Peru, and differences between UK constituent nations. **Results.** Brexit eliminated the validity of the European pet passport. Dogs from Peru — not listed in Part 1 — must comply with the full protocol: ISO microchip, rabies vaccination, RFFIT/FAVN ≥ 0.5 IU/mL after a 30-day wait, and three additional post-serology months (minimum 4.5-month process). **Conclusion.** The AHC issued by an official veterinarian is the central document of the post-Brexit process and its correct management is decisive for animal admission at authorized UK ports of entry.

Keywords: APHA, Brexit, Animal Health Certificate, AHC, DEFRA, RFFIT, Part 1, UK pet importation, Peru

On 1 January 2021, the United Kingdom ceased to be part of the European pet passport system. The Animal Health Certificate (AHC), issued by the official veterinarian in the country of origin and validated by APHA, replaced the EU passport. This article analyses the technical implications of this change for exports from Peru, with particular focus on timelines, AHC requirements, and the most frequent errors.

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Section 1 -- Before and after Brexit for pets

Until 31 December 2020, the United Kingdom accepted the European pet passport as the sole document for the entry of dogs, cats and ferrets from EU countries and those listed as equivalents. Peru was never on that privileged list, so the post-Brexit process, although more complex administratively, does not represent a fundamental change in technical requirements for Peruvian exporters: rabies serology and correctly sequenced vaccination were already mandatory.

What changed substantially is the institutional framework: the Animal and Plant Health Agency (APHA), part of the Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs (DEFRA), took full responsibility for the pet importation system, including the design of the central document: the Animal Health Certificate (AHC). Brexit also eliminated the possibility of using the European passport for animals that, although originating from third countries like Peru, transited through EU countries before entering the UK: since 2021, the AHC is the only valid document regardless of the itinerary.

1.1 Country classification: Part 1 vs. unlisted countries

APHA establishes a fundamental distinction between countries included on the Part 1 list (countries with simplified access, recognized as sanitary equivalents) and the rest of the world. Part 1 countries include EU member states, the EEA, Switzerland and a limited number of additional countries that APHA has assessed as equivalent in their health

standards. Peru is not included on the Part 1 list.

This distinction has direct implications: for dogs from Part 1 countries, the entry document is the European passport or equivalent, without requiring RFFIT. For dogs from unlisted countries like Peru, the full protocol is mandatory: microchip, vaccination, RFFIT, three-month waiting period post-serology, tapeworm treatment, and AHC issued by an official veterinarian.

Section 2 -- The Animal Health Certificate (AHC)

2.1 What it is and who issues it

The AHC is the official document certifying the health status of a companion animal for entry into the United Kingdom. It must be issued by an authorized official veterinarian in the country of origin. In Peru, this corresponds to an official SENASA veterinarian or an accredited veterinarian authorized to issue export documents endorsed by SENASA.

The AHC has a validity of 10 days from issuance to entry into the United Kingdom. This window is extremely tight and is one of the main sources of operational error: a rescheduled flight that exceeds 10 days from the AHC's issuance invalidates the document and requires full re-issuance. For return trips from the UK to the same country of origin (with the same animal under the same conditions), the AHC is valid for 4 months.

2.2 Information that the AHC must contain

The AHC is a structured document with specific sections that must be completed with precision:

- Animal identification: ISO 11784/11785 microchip number, species, breed, sex, approximate date of birth or age, color and distinguishing marks. The microchip must be read and verified by the issuing veterinarian at the time of AHC issuance, and the recorded number must match exactly with all other documents.

- Owner and destination data: name, address in the country of origin, and destination address in the United Kingdom.
- Rabies vaccination history: commercial product name, manufacturing laboratory, batch number, date of administration, and vaccine expiry date. The vaccine must have been administered when the animal already had the microchip implanted.
- RFFIT or FAVN result: laboratory that performed the analysis (must be EU-approved or APHA-recognized), sample extraction date, analysis date, result expressed in IU/mL. The result must be ≥ 0.5 IU/mL. The sample must have been collected at least 30 days after primary vaccination or the last booster if the previous schedule had lapsed.
- Tapeworm treatment (dogs only): medication name (praziquantel), dose administered (minimum 50 mg/kg), exact date and time of administration, name and signature of the administering veterinarian. Treatment must be performed between 24 hours and 5 days (120 hours) before entry into the UK.
- Health declaration: the veterinarian declares that the animal was examined on the stated date and showed no clinical signs of infectious or parasitic disease that could pose a threat to public or animal health.
- Official veterinarian signature and stamp: with registration number and contact details verifiable by APHA.

Critical frequent error: tapeworm treatment section The praziquantel section is the most frequently completed with errors. The date and time of administration must be precise to the minute (not just the day). If the animal arrives at a POAO and the time recorded in the AHC does not comply with the 24-120 hour window before entry, the animal may be detained. APHA interprets this window strictly. For Lima-London flights with connections, calculate the praziquantel timing relative to arrival at the UK POAO, not departure time from Lima.

Section 3 -- Specific requirements for dogs from Peru

Peru is not included on the APHA Part 1 list. Dogs from Peru must therefore comply with the full protocol for unlisted countries. The mandatory sequence is:

- ISO 11784/11785 microchip implanted before the rabies vaccination that will be used for export. The microchip number must be readable with universal ISO scanners.
- Rabies vaccination with an authorized vaccine in the country of origin, with the animal already microchipped. Only inactivated virus vaccines count (not live attenuated). The administration date sets the start of the 30-day counter.
- 30-day wait after primary vaccination (or booster if the previous schedule had lapsed) before blood collection for RFFIT/FAVN.
- RFFIT or FAVN at an EU-approved laboratory or APHA-recognized equivalent: result ≥ 0.5 IU/mL. The date of the positive result sets the start of the 3-month counter.
- 3-month wait from the date of the positive RFFIT result before traveling to the United Kingdom.
- Tapeworm treatment (praziquantel) between 24 hours and 5 days (120 hours) before entry into the UK, administered and certified by a veterinarian.
- AHC issued a maximum of 10 days before travel. The AHC cannot be issued before the tapeworm treatment.

Minimum total timeline from Peru The combination of 30 days post-vaccine + RFFIT laboratory time (7-14 days) + 3 months waiting period + tapeworm treatment + AHC represents a minimum of 4.5 months from initial vaccination to travel. For animals requiring primary vaccination from scratch, the total timeframe exceeds 5 months.

Section 4 -- Tapeworm treatment: technical basis and protocol

Treatment against *Echinococcus multilocularis* (the fox tapeworm, which can infect dogs and in whose biological cycle the dog acts as the definitive host) is a UK-specific requirement for dogs (not applicable to cats or ferrets). This parasitosis is present in

continental Europe but absent in the United Kingdom and Ireland, which maintain this phytosanitary barrier as part of their island biosecurity strategy.

Praziquantel must be administered at a minimum dose of 50 mg/kg body weight and recorded in the AHC with precise date and time. Administration by the owner is not accepted: it must be a veterinarian who administers and certifies it. In Peru, since *Echinococcus multilocularis* is not present nationally, the treatment has no local epidemiological justification, but it is a UK health policy requirement applicable to all dogs from unlisted countries, regardless of the parasitological profile of the country of origin.

4.1 Differences between dogs, cats and ferrets

Cats and ferrets are exempt from the tapeworm treatment requirement to enter the UK. However, both cats and ferrets are subject to all other requirements for unlisted countries: microchip, rabies vaccination, RFFIT with result ≥ 0.5 IU/mL, 3-month waiting period post-serology, and AHC. The exemption from antiparasitic treatment is based on the epidemiology of *E. multilocularis*: cats are not relevant definitive hosts of this parasite unlike canids.

Section 5 -- Authorized ports of entry (POAO)

Not all UK ports and airports are authorized to receive companion animals from non-Part 1 countries. The authorized Points of Entry for Animals and Animal Products (POAO) for companion animals from third countries are specific and must be verified before confirming the travel itinerary.

- Heathrow Airport (LHR): most commonly used for exports from Peru. Has permanent veterinary inspection facilities.
- Gatwick Airport (LGW): authorized for certain species and flights. Verify operational capacity before travel.
- Manchester Airport (MAN): POAO authorized for companion animals.

- Edinburgh (EDI) and Glasgow (GLA) airports: authorized with veterinary inspection time restrictions. Confirm availability in advance.
- Ferry ports: Dover, Folkestone (Channel Tunnel) and Portsmouth have limitations for third-country animals with AHC. Verify each case individually.

Mandatory POAO verification before purchasing the ticket The veterinarian and owner must verify that the arrival airport is a POAO authorized for the animal's species (dog/cat/ferret) and that the flight arrives during veterinary inspection operating hours. Arriving outside POAO operating hours may mean the animal is not inspected and is detained until the next working inspection day, with confinement costs charged to the importer.

Section 6 -- Differences between the UK's constituent nations

The APHA/DEFRA regulatory framework applies to Great Britain (England, Scotland and Wales). Northern Ireland has a special status under the Northern Ireland Protocol (also known as the Windsor Framework since 2023): it remains integrated in the single veterinary area with the Republic of Ireland and, by extension, with the EU. This means that animals entering Northern Ireland from Peru may do so under the framework of EU Regulation 576/2013, using the European AHC rather than the APHA AHC for Great Britain, provided the port of entry is authorized under this framework.

This distinction is practically relevant because an owner planning to travel with their pet to Belfast may find that the documentary process differs from that for London, and that SENASA veterinarians must issue an AHC in EU format rather than the APHA format for Great Britain. Before planning the itinerary, it is essential to determine the destination constituent nation and the applicable regulatory framework.

Section 7 -- Most frequent errors in Peru-UK exports

7.1 AHC issued by non-official veterinarian

The AHC must be issued by an official veterinarian (in Peru, accredited by SENASA for issuance of export documents). A private clinical veterinarian without official accreditation cannot issue a valid AHC for the UK. This is one of the most serious errors as it completely invalidates the document and may result in boarding denial at origin or rejection at destination.

7.2 Tapeworm treatment outside the time window

The 24-120 hour window for praziquantel is strictly enforced. Treatment administered 6 days before entry (outside the window), or on the day of the flight but more than 24 hours before arriving at the POAO (depending on flight duration), results in non-compliance. For Lima-Madrid-London flights with stopovers, the praziquantel administration time must be calculated relative to the arrival time at the UK POAO, not the departure time from Lima.

7.3 Valid RFFIT result but 3-month period not completed

An RFFIT result ≥ 0.5 IU/mL is necessary but not sufficient. The 3-month waiting period from the date of the positive result is mandatory and independent of the titre obtained. An animal with a titre of 2.0 IU/mL traveling less than 3 months after serology equally fails to meet the requirement.

7.4 Microchip not readable or number discrepant

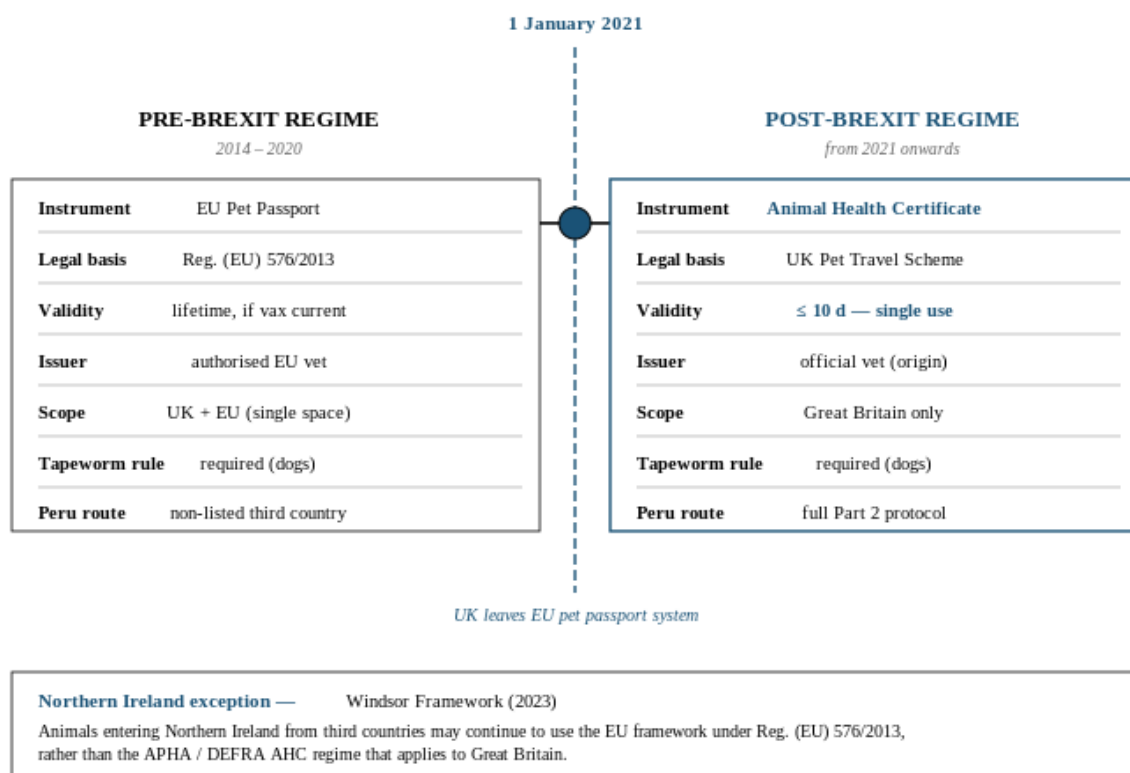
At the POAO, the APHA officer will physically verify the animal's microchip. If the number read does not match that recorded in the AHC, the animal is classified as non-compliant regardless of other documents. Poorly implanted microchips (migration) or those with defective reading are a frequent cause of detention at destination.

Clinical evidence -- Zoovet Travel 2013-2026 Over 13 years of managing Peru-UK pet exports, 41% of cases with destination complications were caused by failure to observe the 3-month post-serology waiting period. The second most frequent group (22%) corresponded to the tapeworm treatment window. The implementation of the post-Brexit AHC has increased documentary complexity compared to the pre-2021 period, but the

fundamental technical requirement structure (microchip + vaccine + RFFIT + wait) was essentially the same for exports from Peru even before Brexit.

Figure 1. UK pet importation regime — before and after Brexit.

Source: Reg. (EU) 576/2013; APHA / DEFRA Pet Travel Scheme (effective 2021-01-01); Windsor Framework (2023) for Northern Ireland.

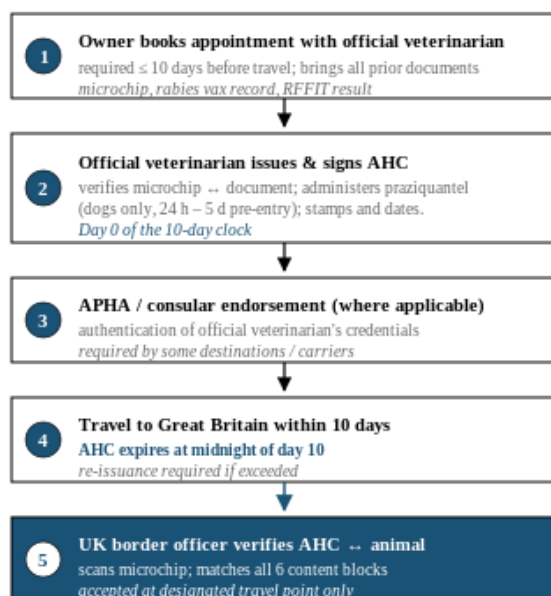


Note — Peru was never on the EU simplified entry list. The Brexit transition is administrative (passport → AHC), not technical, for Peruvian exporters: microchip, rabies vaccination, RFFIT ≥ 0.5 IU/mL, 3-month post-titre wait and praziquantel still apply.

Figure 2. Animal Health Certificate — issuance process and document anatomy.

Source: APHA Pet Travel guidance, DEFRA Statutory Guidance (2021–present). AHC is single-use; a new certificate is required for each journey to Great Britain.

A — Issuance process



B — AHC content blocks

ANIMAL HEALTH CERTIFICATE
§ 1 ANIMAL IDENTIFICATION ISO 11784/11785 microchip · species · breed sex · DOB · coat colour
§ 2 OWNER DECLARATION non-commercial purpose · ≤ 5 animals
§ 3 RABIES VACCINATION manufacturer · batch · date · validity microchip implanted BEFORE this date
§ 4 RFFIT SEROLOGY (Part 2 / non-listed) sample date ≥ 30 d post-vax · ≥ 0.5 IU/mL approved laboratory · ≥ 3-month post-sample wait
§ 5 ECHINOCOCCUS TREATMENT (dogs) praziquantel ≥ 50 mg/kg · vet-administered 24 h – 5 d before entry · timestamped
§ 6 OFFICIAL VETERINARIAN ATTESTATION signature · stamp · CMVP / equivalent ID issuance date — clock starts here

Critical — Any missing block, microchip-document mismatch, or excursion beyond the 10-day window invalidates the AHC and triggers re-issuance.

Praziquantel must be vet-administered; owner self-administration is not accepted by APHA.

Actors — ● Official veterinarian (origin) ○ APHA endorser / UK border officer

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